

Introduction

There is hardly a person you would meet today who has never played a video game in his life. From the old video game arcades to the modern home consoles and portable handheld units, the popularity of this medium cannot be denied.

Yet, video games come with a tainted image, especially in India. There's a common misconception that they are for kids, and not the domain of adults. This is compounded by activists who say that these games make children more violent, show inappropriate graphic content, etc. In a way, it's almost like someone took all the arguments against the TV in the last few decades and changed it to 'video games'.

If anyone actually looked at the tons of research available on all of the above accusations, they would find that video games are more than just a few minutes of escapist fun. Apart from refining hand-eye coordination, gaming helps in exercising the mind, builds team-play skills in multiplayer games and average gamers have been found to be better at strategising than non-gamers. As for inappropriate content, there are 'intended user' ratings for games similar to the ones for movies.

This is not to say that video games should be played night and day, but to use it moderately like any other thing. Like any activity, if gaming is pursued in excess of normal bodily limits, you will end up harming yourself.

Quantifying gaming in India faces a peculiar problem due to the grey market here. Gamers predominantly use the PC, mostly because of the high piracy rates on that front. Sony's PlayStation 3 console has not been cracked yet and while Microsoft's Xbox 360 offers that option, the number of bugs that can render it obsolete mean that a lot of gamers prefer to keep their warranty intact.

Additionally, the grey markets sell the consoles themselves at a significantly lower price than the retail ones. A large percentage of sales for the Nintendo Wii, which can be easily cracked and used with pirated games, come exclusively from the grey markets. This leads to a lot of console sales that don't get accounted for either.